

BERRIES FOR THE PRINCESS

2026

The Chief of the Royal Guard chose the hour carefully.

It was just before dusk, when the market square was at its fullest... when men were tired enough to listen and poor enough to hope. He stood on the stone plinth at the center of the city, helmet under one arm, cloak arranged so the royal seal caught the light. He waited until the noise softened into irritation, then raised his voice.

“By decree of His Majesty the King,” he announced, “a request has been issued for *one hundred razzleberries*.”

The name rippled through the square like a dropped plate. People turned. Merchants stopped counting. A woman froze with a loaf half-wrapped in cloth.

“The first citizen to deliver the full order to the castle gates,” the Guard continued, “will be paid ten silver shillings per berry.”

He paused.

“One thousand shillings.”

The silence was palpable as the crowd was in shock.

A thousand shillings was not wealth; it was escape. It was debt erased, winters softened, children fed without counting. It was the kind of number men only encountered in stories.

Razzleberries were real enough. Everyone knew that much. They grew wild in the northern hills and the marshlands beyond the old roads. They were small, dark red, and sour enough to make the jaw ache. They were also rare... usually found alone, sometimes two if you were lucky. Most people who had seen one had not been looking for it.

No one asked *why* the King wanted them.

By the time the Chief stepped down, the square was already emptying.

At first it was almost festive.

Men traveled in pairs, then small groups. There was talk of sharing the reward, of fairness, of brotherhood. They joked about buying taverns and marrying well. They marked likely groves on maps drawn from memory and rumor. The roads filled with purpose.

The first berries were found easily enough. One here. One there. They were held up like proof of concept, stained fingers raised in triumph. A man with three berries was already rich by the standards of his life.

Then the pace slowed.

Men spread farther apart. The groups thinned. The jokes stopped. A

rumor began to circulate - quietly at first, then louder - that there might not be enough berries to satisfy the decree. That the number had been chosen without knowledge, or worse, without care.

Someone said there were perhaps two hundred in the entire kingdom. Someone else said fewer.

Men began to hide their finds.

A man disappeared in the hills. Another was found days later at the bottom of a ravine, his pack split open, berries gone. No one said murder aloud, but no one needed to.

The groups dissolved entirely after that.

By the second week, there were injuries everywhere.

A farmer returned with a shattered ankle and one berry clenched in his fist. A pair of brothers stopped speaking after one accused the other of skimming. Knives were drawn and put away. Once, not put away.

Two men emerged as inevitable.

One was lean, careful, meticulous. He tracked growth patterns and moved constantly, never sleeping in the same place twice. The other was larger, brutal in his efficiency, taking berries from men who could not protect them and calling it luck.

Between them, they gathered nearly all that could be gathered.

When word spread that each had passed fifty, the countryside emptied of competitors.

There was nothing left to find except them.

They met at dawn, on a stretch of bare ground stripped clean by passing feet.

There was no speech. No ritual.

The fight was clumsy and fast. The careful man zigged when he should have zagged and the larger man landed a fatal blow. It was over in less than a minute. The larger man stood over him for a long time, breathing hard, then pried the berries from the dead man's pack one by one, counting as he went.

He arrived at the city alone.

The Chief of the Royal Guard inspected the delivery personally. One hundred berries. Bruised. Overripe. Still acceptable.

The payment was counted out in silence. Heavy coins, stacked neatly, a lifetime reduced to weight. The man bowed. His hands shook as he gathered the silver.

No one asked him what it had cost.

He left the city before nightfall, already planning how far the money would carry him from the memory of the hills.

In the castle, the King regarded the berries with mild curiosity.

"So these are them," he said.

He scooped them into his palm and crushed them all at once. The skins split. Juice ran between his fingers, dark and thick, filling the crystal glass beneath. He tasted what remained on his hand and grimaced.

“Sour,” he said. “Unpleasant.”

Still, he smiled as he carried the glass into the nursery.
The princess sat on the floor amid her toys, face flushed from crying.
She reached for him reflexively.

“Look what Daddy got you,” the King said brightly. “The razzle-razzle.”

She sniffed the glass, hesitated, and began to wail.

The Royal Nanny stepped forward, startled.
“Your Majesty,” she said carefully, “she didn’t say *razzle-razzle*. She said *rattle-rattle*.”

As if on cue, the princess shook the wooden rattle in her hand.

The King looked at the glass. Then at the child. Then he laughed once, softly.

“Oh, well.” he said.

He turned and poured the juice into the trough outside the kitchens.
The pigs surged forward eagerly, snorting and shoving, staining the straw red.

The King wiped his hands on a cloth and went to dinner.

Far from the castle, a man counted silver coins by firelight, and for the first time since leaving the hills, found that nothing he owned could buy him sleep.